

THE SAGA OF THE INNER RIFT

IN SEARCH OF THE FORGOTTEN SPARK

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Chapter One, in full

To read before deciding whether the crossing is yours.

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CHAPTER I

THE CALL OF THE INNER RIFT

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Veridiana was a city built to be forgotten. Its streets bore the names of saints no one had invoked in generations. Its clocks marked the exact hour of nothing important. Its sidewalks were wide and deserted most mornings, like open mouths waiting for a word that never came. It was the kind of place where people were born, grew up, learned to love their boredom, and then died — all without ever once wondering if there was something else beyond the city's edges.

Auron Sollis was thirty-three years old, and the most talented cartographer Veridiana had ever produced. Which, let's be honest, wasn't exactly a towering achievement. He drew maps for merchants who knew every bend of the river by heart. Maps for hunters who trusted the stars and the wind's own guts more than any scrap of paper. Maps that, deep down, nobody actually needed. Except Auron himself.

Because tracing boundaries gave him something he couldn't have named at the time: the illusion that the world was contained. Predictable. Safe. If there was a border on the page, there was a border in reality. If there was a drawn edge, there was an edge beyond which nothing bad could happen. It was crooked logic, but it worked. It had worked for thirty-three years.

His mother, before she died, had said something he never fully understood: "The fear of falling is what keeps us on the ground. But the ground is

a lie too.”

Auron was twenty-one when she said it, lying in a hospital bed with a voice already thin as tissue paper. He hadn’t answered. He’d just stared at the blue veins showing through the translucent skin of her forearm — like rivers on a map, he’d thought. Like rivers on a map he didn’t know how to read.

That was why he became a cartographer. That was why he never questioned it.

That was why he woke, on the morning of his thirty-third birthday, to the wrong kind of silence outside.

It wasn’t ordinary silence. It wasn’t that gap that exists between the city’s usual noises — like a rest in a piece of music, a breath between notes. It was a silence that sucked sound in, pulling it inward the way a hole at the bottom of the ocean pulls in water.

The rooster that lived in neighbor Dona Luzia’s yard didn’t crow. It was the most punctual rooster in Veridiana — everyone set their morning mood by its six o’clock shriek. Silence. The baker on the corner, who’d shouted “hot bread, hot bread!” every day for as long as Auron could remember, didn’t shout. Silence. The wind, which always rattled his bedroom window with its usual lazy persistence, like someone ringing a doorbell without really wanting to be let in, simply stopped. It didn’t taper off. It stopped.

Auron sat on the edge of the bed for a good thirty seconds, listening to nothing.

Then he put his feet on the floor. Cold, but normal. He stood. Ran a hand over his face. Two days of stubble. Heavy eyes. Everything in order. Everything completely, absolutely, terrifyingly in order.

Except for the light.

Light came through the shutter slats in straight, clean bars, with no dust dancing in them. Auron stared at that for a long time. The dust was always there — a constant of the room, those slow-motion particles drifting through the sunbeams. But now there was nothing. The air seemed to have given up on moving. It looked gelled, fixed, as if the world had frozen in a

single instant and he were the only thing still moving inside it.

Auron went to the closet. Opened it. Grabbed a shirt. Went to put it on and realized he was still wearing yesterday's clothes. He changed everything. Tried to ignore the strange tingling at the back of his neck.

Then he faced the mirror.

It was a full-length mirror mounted on the wardrobe door. Auron had inherited it from his mother, who'd inherited it from his grandmother, who used to say the mirror "heartwarded" the family — a word that existed in no dictionary anywhere, but which his grandmother pronounced with such conviction that no one had ever thought to question it. The mirror had a frame of darkened wood, carved with leaves and birds that the years had worn smooth, almost to nothing.

Auron was in it.

But the reflection moved a second late.

One second. Doesn't sound like much. It is.

When you stand in front of a mirror and make a movement — raise a hand, furrow your brow, blink — the reflection is supposed to do exactly the same thing at exactly the same time. That's what mirrors do. It's the only thing mirrors do. It's the whole reason mirrors exist.

Auron's reflection furrowed its brow a second after he did.

Auron raised his right hand. The reflection raised its left — as it should — but only after a pause that seemed to last an eternity and, at the same time, lasted exactly one second: heavy, viscous, impossible.

"This isn't happening," Auron said out loud.

His voice didn't echo. It was swallowed by the same silence that had eaten the sounds of the street.

Auron took three steps back. The reflection took three steps forward. Not backward, as it should have — forward. As if it were closing the distance from inside the glass, from inside that cold, parallel world that exists on the far side of every mirrored surface.

The reflection stopped.

It looked at Auron.

And blinked — first the left eye, then the right, in a deliberate sequence no nervous tic could ever fake.

Auron blinked back, involuntarily, with both eyes at once.

The reflection smiled. Slowly. With a familiarity that was disturbing precisely because it was familiar — it was the smile Auron sometimes saw in old photographs, from when he was a child and the world hadn't yet hardened into certainties.

Auron didn't smile. He ran.

The living room was modest. A worn leather couch holding the memory of a thousand tedious afternoons. A bookshelf with books on geography, history, cartography, and two novels he'd been given as gifts and never finished. The worktable, wide and sturdy, covered in rolled parchment and dried-out inks and brushes whose bristles had gone crooked from years of use. A window looking out on the garden, where a fig tree grew figs far too good for a city as forgettable as Veridiana.

And the wall clock.

The clock was the oldest thing Auron owned. It had come to him through his paternal grandfather, a man Auron had known only for the first six years of his life before the man died — a man with a thick beard and the smell of tobacco, who spoke little and watched everything. The clock was German, a pendulum clock, with a porcelain face stained yellow with age and two blackened iron hands — one for hours, one for minutes.

Since Auron had inherited it at eighteen, the clock had never once needed winding. That was strange. Auron had always known it was strange. But there were things a person learned not to ask about, and his grandfather's clock was one of them.

His grandfather used to say the clock ran on longing, in that voice he used when he was being serious but pretending to joke. Auron had filed the line away as one of the old man's jokes. Keep it in the heart, file it in the drawer marked "don't examine this," move on.

Now the clock had three hands.

The third was thin as a sewing needle and red as dried blood. It ran backward — not counterclockwise the way the minute hand simply reversed direction, but differently, as if it refused to take part in the same logic as the other two. It didn't mark seconds. The numbers it pointed to were impossible: 13:65. 14:70. 15:75. Numbers that didn't exist in this world, that couldn't exist in any system of measurement Auron knew.

The normal hands moved forward with time's familiar cadence. The red hand crept backward, like a fish rowing against the current, like someone walking backward up a descending escalator. Together, the three formed a dance that wasn't absurd at all — it was strangely logical, a logic Auron had no vocabulary to describe.

How long did he stand there watching? He couldn't say. Time seemed to have handed in its resignation that morning.

His longing for his grandfather, suddenly, didn't feel like a joke anymore.

That was when the voice arrived.

It wasn't an audible sound. Auron realized that even before he understood what he was hearing. It wasn't something that arrived through the ears, that vibrated the eardrum, that traveled through the bones of the skull to the auditory nerve. It was a direct impression — as if someone had poured words straight into the fluid bathing his spinal cord. As if the words had been written in invisible ink on the very fabric of his thoughts.

The voice had no gender. No age. No accent, no texture, none of the particular roughness every human voice carries. It had only one quality, and it took Auron a while to name it:

Remembrance.

It was something he had always known and had forgotten he knew. Like the lyrics to a song you sang as a child, suddenly resurfacing whole and perfect, with no idea where it came from.

The map you carry isn't of the world. It's of you.

Auron spun around. The room was empty.

"Who's there?" he asked.

The voice didn't answer. Maybe because it didn't need to.

Auron looked down at his own hands. Turned the palms up — and stopped breathing.

The lines of life, heart, and head were there, just as they'd always been. But now, etched into the skin like tiny golden tattoos, there were patterns he'd never noticed before. Constellations. Concentric circles, one inside another, like ripples from a stone dropped into a still lake. An eye inside a triangle. A wingless bird.

The markings glowed. Not much — not enough to light the room, nothing like the harshness of artificial light. Just enough for Auron to know, with total certainty, that they weren't in his head.

"That's not possible," he whispered.

But there it was. On his own hands. On his own skin.

Auron dressed in a hurry, left the house without coffee, took the stairs two at a time, and burst out onto the street like someone surfacing from a deep dive. The sun hit his face. The air smelled of wet earth from rain that had fallen before dawn.

He needed people. Noise. The friction of other humans, the kind that dulls whatever solitude amplifies.

Veridiana's central market was a seven-minute walk from Auron's house — he knew the exact number because he'd once timed it out of boredom, and the distance had lodged itself in his memory like any other piece of cartographic data. The stalls were set up, the fruit stacked high, vendors shouting prices and announcements in the thick voice of people who spend their lives talking over crowds.

Normal. Everything normal.

Auron took a deep breath and let himself be swallowed by the flow of people. He bought a cheese bread from a tray. Bit into it. It tasted like paper. He tried to ignore that.

But when he passed Dona Mira's stall — the same orange stall he'd been buying from for ten years, where Dona Mira always threw in an extra orange for free and said it was "because you've got the face of a boy who needs his

vitamins” — the old woman stopped arranging her fruit and looked at him with an expression he’d never seen on her before.

“You’re different today, Auron.”

“Different how?”

Dona Mira pursed her lips. She was a small, sturdy woman, with white hair pinned up in a bun and hands that looked carved from hardwood. She looked Auron up and down like a doctor assessing a symptom.

“More inside,” she said, finally.

“More inside what?”

“Inside yourself.” She shrugged, as if it were obvious, and went back to arranging her oranges. “Take two. Go on.”

Auron took the oranges. Kept walking. Tried to work out what that could possibly mean — more inside — and arrived at no satisfying conclusion.

In the middle of the square stood a stone bench beneath an almond tree. Auron had known that bench since childhood. He’d sat there with his mother more times than he could count, eaten ice cream there, studied there, sat there staring at nothing in particular while the city did what cities do. He sat down now with the same automatic pull of someone returning to an anchor point.

He tried to convince himself it was exhaustion. Or stress. Or maybe the beginning of a fever — the hallucinations that come before a high fever could produce strange things, he’d read that somewhere. A mirror that moved a beat too late. A voice that came from nowhere outside him. Tattoos appearing out of nothing. Yes. It had to be a fever.

But the truth was, he had never felt so completely, terrifyingly awake.

It was as if a layer of dust had been wiped from his eyes — not ordinary dust, the kind from closed windows and poorly swept rooms, but another kind, older, the kind that builds up over perception when you spend years seeing only the outside of things and never once ask what’s on the inside.

The people around him looked translucent. Not physically — they still had flesh and bone and colorful clothes, same as always. But Auron could

see, behind every face, a kind of inner churning. As if people were aquariums, and he could suddenly see the fish swimming inside them.

A middle-aged woman walked by pushing a shopping cart, wearing the expression of someone carrying the whole world on her back. Behind her, Auron saw a six-year-old girl running through a summer afternoon, begging to be carried, laughing at something only children find funny. The woman was that girl. Still was, somewhere inside her.

A man in a dark suit talked in a phone booth with the urgent intensity of someone solving a crisis. Behind him, a sixteen-year-old boy stared at his own hands and thought: I don't want to be this. I don't want to be a lawyer. I don't want any of this. The man was that boy. Still was, somewhere he'd never managed to silence that voice.

A small child ran across the square chasing a pigeon. Behind her, nothing. Just the child — whole, present, without layers, without old trapped versions of herself. Auron felt a pang of something it took him a second to recognize as envy.

“What’s happening to me?” he murmured.

You’re waking up.

The voice again. Gentler this time. Almost tender.

Auron clapped his hands over his ears. It didn't help. The voice came from inside — from somewhere so deep there were no ears to cover.

The day dragged on like a river of molasses.

Auron went home. Tried to work. There was an overdue commission — a map of the upper course of the Lethe River for a salt merchant who needed to know the river shortcuts before flood season. It was the kind of job Auron could do with his eyes closed. He took out a blank sheet of parchment. Arranged his brushes by thickness. Opened the ink jars. Glanced over the field notes from his last expedition along the river.

He began to draw.

His hand didn't obey.

Instead of the Lethe's familiar bends, his fingers traced a circle. Large, precise, with a fluidity that wasn't the fluidity of technical skill but of some-

thing that came from before technique. Inside the circle, another circle. Inside that, a point. Then radial lines spreading out from the center like the rays of a star, or the arms of a galactic spiral.

Auron stopped. Looked at the parchment.

It was a mandala. He had never drawn a mandala in his life. He hadn't known he knew how.

He stared at it for a length of time he couldn't measure. There was something disturbingly familiar about the drawing — like a face you recognize but can't place. Like a word in a language you've never studied, that somehow still makes sense.

He rolled up the parchment. Unrolled another. Tried again.

His hand drew another mandala. Different this time — more complex, patterns within patterns, the kind of geometry people start seeing when they stare at fractals too long. Auron threw the brush to the floor and went to the bathroom, small, its walls covered in colorful broken tiles — yellows, greens, and blues, like an imperfect mosaic — and a rustic sink where the water ran while the morning light danced across the ceramic, throwing off small sparks that never asked for applause.



Lian's forge was the only mouth of fire in Veridiana, and Auron had been avoiding it for two years for the same reason he avoided mirrors: because inside it, someone saw him.

That afternoon, he went in.

The heat reached him before the smell, and the smell before the sound — charcoal, wet metal, and the wheeze of the bellows. Lian had his back turned, bent over the anvil, hammering a piece that had no shape yet. He did not stop hammering. He struck three more times, counted to some number only he knew, and only then plunged the iron into the water. The hiss filled the workshop.

"You look like a man who didn't sleep," said Lian, without turning around.

"I didn't."

“Then sit.”

There was no stool. Auron sat on an upturned crate, the way he used to sit at fifteen, when the two of them were the same height and had none of the same doubts.

Lian took the iron back out, held it up against the light from the door, and made a face. He put it back in the fire.

“Crooked,” he explained. “I hurried.”

“And now?”

“Now it heats up again.”

Auron laughed, and the laugh came out wrong, too loud for the workshop.

“That’s it?”

“That’s it.” Lian looked at him for the first time. “What did you think it would be? You want me to throw it out?”

“I’d throw it out.”

“I know.” Lian turned back to the bellows. “You did.”

He did not say Elisa’s name. He didn’t need to. Lian had never needed to say things in order to say them, and that was exactly why it had taken Auron two years to walk through that door.

They stayed quiet while the metal heated. The fire changed color three times. Auron noticed that he could follow the changes without getting bored, and noticed too that this was new: on any other day of his life, he would have been drumming his fingers.

“Lian.”

“Mm.”

“If you saw something that can’t exist, would you tell anyone?”

The blacksmith shrugged, not taking his eyes off the flame.

“I see it every day. Iron goes in hard and comes out soft. Then it goes in soft and comes out hard. If I told that to somebody who doesn’t work with fire, they’d think I drink.”

“It isn’t the same thing.”

“No. But the question is.”

Auron opened his mouth to answer and found nothing to say, which was also new. Cartographers always have something to say: they have scale, they have a legend, they have a compass rose. He had none of that in there.

Lian drew the iron from the fire, struck twice — slowly now, counting his own breath — and set it against the water. This time the hiss was short.

“There,” he said. “Straightened.”

Then he wiped his hands on the leg of his apron, which accomplished nothing, and went to the bench. He came back with an orange.

He held it in both hands, and both hands were black with the forge, and he held it out like that — both palms up, the fruit in the middle, the way a man carries something that might get away from him.

“From Dona Mira. She sent it for you, not for me. Said you’ve been more inside lately.”

“More inside what?”

“She didn’t explain. I assumed you’d know.”

Auron took the orange. It was warm from the heat of the workshop, and there were two dark thumb marks on the peel, one on each side.

It would be a long time before he understood that he had just seen, in a neighborhood workshop, with a man with dirty hands and a crooked bar of iron, nearly everything he would cross an entire kingdom to learn. That material is only good for anything after it burns. That haste bends things. That the one who straightens does not throw away. And that there is a way of offering something — both hands open, nothing hidden, the object in the middle — that cannot be learned, because it is not technique: it is what is left of a man when he stops wanting something in return.

That afternoon, he only thought that the orange was warm.

He thanked him. He put it in his coat pocket. He walked to the door and stopped there, one hand on the frame, in the manner of a man about to say what he came to say.

“Lian, I—“

“I know,” said the blacksmith, already turned away, already hammering. “Come back whenever. The door’s the same one.”

Auron left. Behind him, the hammer went back to counting.



Afternoon settled slowly over Veridiana, the way it did in autumn, painting everything a lazy orange. Auron opened a bottle of red wine he'd been saving for special occasions — and decided, in a crooked bit of emergency logic, that this counted as one. He filled a glass. Drank.

The wine tasted different.

Not bad. Just different, in a way he had no words for. It was as if, instead of simply tasting the wine, he were experiencing it — its entire history, condensed into sips. He tasted the grapes that had been crushed underfoot in a stone press, still warm from the sun. Tasted the rain that had fallen in the final week of harvest, soaking the leaves, subtly shifting the sugar in the fruit. Tasted the calloused hands of the farmer who had picked every cluster with the care you'd give something precious.

Auron drank the second glass more slowly.

By the third, he'd sunk back into the couch, staring up at the ceiling. It was white, with a diagonal crack he'd never fixed because it always seemed on the verge of healing itself. It never healed. Never got worse either. It just stayed there, that crack, like a quiet comment on the nature of things.

I'm losing my mind.

But some part of him — small, stubborn, glowing like an ember that won't go out in the rain — was radiant. Was relieved. Was quietly singing a song with no words:

Finally. Finally you're seeing.

Auron threw his arm over his eyes and tried not to listen to that part of himself.

Evening arrived the way it does when you're not expecting it — all at once, the day suddenly gone, the orange turning to purple turning to deep blue, and the first stars appearing over Veridiana's rooftops like punctuation in a text nobody had written.

Auron sat in the living room. Defeated — that was the right word. Not the kind of defeat that comes from a battle, but the kind that comes from

resisting something that's going to happen anyway. Like resisting the tide.

The orange-purple light came in through the windows, coating the rolled parchments in the honey of the day's last light. The three-handed clock kept up its absurd ballet on the wall, the red hand obstinately reversing against the current of time. The mirror in his bedroom — he'd shut the wardrobe door on it. He didn't want to look.

Then he saw the Rift.

It hung in the space where the wall should have been. It didn't cut through the wallpaper — that yellowed paper with the leaf pattern that had been there since before Auron was born. It didn't tear the plaster, didn't crack the brick, didn't disturb a single physical layer that made up a wall.

The Rift simply hung there in space, as if the air itself had split down the middle. A vertical crack in the fabric — not of the visible world, but of something that existed behind the visible world, underneath it, like the wire armature hidden beneath a clay sculpture.

Blue poured out of it. Not just any blue — a blue darker than any blue Auron had ever seen. Darker than the ocean at midnight, darker than the sky in the instant before sunrise. A blue that seemed to have infinite depth, as if on the other side of the Rift there wasn't a wall at all, but an entire universe.

And out of it came a melody.

It wasn't a melody heard with the ears. It was felt in the bones, in the teeth, in the curve of the spine, in the places where nerves branch out like trees in winter. It was a song the whole body recognized, that every cell recognized, as if the melody were some ancestral language the body had always spoken and the mind had simply forgotten.

The melody said:

You've been here before. You never left.

Auron rose from the couch slowly. His feet found the floor. His knees worked. His heart raced — not with fear, but with that particular kind of excitement that's fear's close relative, living in the same neighborhood, just a different house.

He walked toward the Rift.

With every step, it grew — or maybe just became more visible, more defined, like an object gaining detail as you approach. By the time he was an arm's length away, it stood a full meter tall.

Auron stopped. Looked at it. It looked back — not with eyes, but with that particular quality of attention that rifts have when they're waiting.

He reached his hand in.

He felt nothing — and that was stranger than if he'd felt cold, or heat, or resistance. His hand simply kept going. Kept going past the point where it should have stopped. His hand was inside the Rift and Auron was outside it, and there was only his forearm crossing that impossible boundary as if no boundary existed at all.

He pulled his hand back out.

His hand was there, whole, all five fingers intact, the golden constellations glowing brighter than before. As if contact with the Rift had fed something.

"If I go in, I won't come back," Auron whispered.

The Rift grew another hand's width.

Auron didn't move for a long time. He stood in front of the Rift with the golden constellations glowing on his palms and his heart taking inventory of everything he had to lose.

The house. The worktable. The parchments. The fig tree outside. The routine — ah, the routine, that comfortable, ungrateful creature he'd fed for thirty-three years the way you feed a pet that will never love you back.

He thought of his grandfather. Of the clock. Of the old man's joke about longing being what moved the gears.

And then he thought of his mother. Not the moment of her death, when she was in the hospital and her skin was so thin you could see the blue veins like rivers on a map nobody had asked him to draw. He thought of a distant afternoon, when he was eight years old and had fallen out of a mango tree.

The mango tree stood in the yard of the house they'd lived in back then — a bigger house, before his father left and everything got smaller. Auron

had climbed too high. He always climbed too high. He was the kind of kid who needed to see what was at the top of everything before he'd come down.

The branch broke. He fell.

The fall seemed to last forever. Seemed to last long enough for the whole world to turn itself inside out — the sky below, the ground above, branches sliding past in slow motion, startled birds bursting into flight, and at the center of it all, the feeling that the ground was a promise that could be broken.

When he opened his eyes, his mother was kneeling beside him. Not screaming, not panicking — just there, the way she was always there, stanching the blood on his knee with her own skirt because there was nothing else at hand. Her eyes were calm. Her voice was calm.

“The blood proves you’re alive. The fall proves you tried.”

Auron Sollis, cartographer of useless borders, closed his eyes. Breathed deep. Felt the air fill him as if for the very first time, as if the previous thirty-three years had just been rehearsal for this one breath.

He opened his eyes.

Looked at the Rift.

And saw, for one second — just one second, in that space between decision and action — not an abyss. A womb.

Auron Sollis jumped.

The fall lasted one second and forever.

There was no wind. No stomach-drop vertigo that comes when the ground disappears. No fear of smashing into something hard and solid and cold. There was only a feeling of being remembered — as if reality itself were recalling that he existed, as if the universe had checked its list, found his name, and said: ah, yes. You. You’re supposed to be here.

Stars streamed past him — not above, not below, but alongside, as if he were falling in the wrong direction according to the laws of physics, in the direction that has no name. Stars that weren’t Veridiana’s stars, not the stars he knew by heart and had charted onto his maps. These were bigger stars,

closer, with a kind of presence that stars seen from a distance never have.

He saw nebulae that breathed. Literally breathed — expanding and contracting in a slow, patient rhythm, like something deep asleep that could be anything at all if woken. He saw geometric shapes turning in perfect stillness, triangles and octahedra and nameless forms beyond anything human geometry could classify, all rotating with the precision of gears in a clock that measured not time, but something else entirely.

And then the ground appeared.

It was a floor of black crystal, polished like a mirror but soft as moss when Auron landed on his knees. There was no impact — not the kind that comes from a collision, bone against surface. There was only arrival. Like the way you fall asleep without ever noticing the exact moment sleep takes you.

Auron knelt there a moment. The golden constellations on his palms glowed against the dark crystal like stars reflected in a lake. He looked down. To the sides. Up.

Up.

The sky was a veil of three moons.

Not three moons like the ones seen from Veridiana, small and distant, gently glowing overhead. Three immense moons, each with the physical presence of something close, their surfaces almost distinguishable — craters, valleys, lines of shadow. Each a different color: one amber, warm as copper heated over fire; one blue-gray, with the luminous chill of steel; one white as fresh milk, its soft glow seeming to come not from the surface but from somewhere deep inside it.

The three orbited one another in a slow spiral, like dancers who had learned to move together so long ago their choreography had become breathing. They were beautiful in a way that ached in the chest.

The crystal floor stretched in every direction as far as he could see, cut here and there by rivers of liquid light — not reflected light, but light with a body, light that ran like water, moving with the same slow indolence as rivers crossing flat plains. And at the center of a circle formed by black stone menhirs — vertical, ancient, holding the stillness of things older than any

civilization — a woman knelt.

She was tending to a bird.

The bird was made of stone. Not a statue — a living, warm creature, with blinking eyes and a chest that rose and fell with breath, made of gray granite stained with moss and ages of accumulated rain. It was the size of a large crow. It bled light from a broken wing — not blood, but something older than blood, something a creature made of stone produces when it's wounded.

The woman sang softly. It was a mantra in a language Auron didn't recognize — not Koine Greek, not Latin, not the Arabic he'd studied for one semester and abandoned, not any language spoken anywhere he could name. A language that seemed to predate language itself, that seemed to be the bedrock every other tongue had grown from.

She passed her hands over the break in the wing with a surgeon's slow precision. Every touch left a trace of gold that fused to the stone like solder, the way metals bond under enough heat.

Auron approached. His footsteps made no sound on the crystal — not because he was trying to be quiet, but because silence was the natural condition of that place, a different silence than the one that had swallowed Veridiana's sounds that morning. This was a living silence, a fertile one, the kind that exists before words rather than after them.

The woman, without seeming to hear him at all, said:

"You landed well. Many fall inside themselves and never find the bottom."

Her voice was calm. Compassionate. Full of pauses that weren't empty — they were presences. She didn't look up from the bird as she spoke.

"Where am I?" Auron asked.

His own voice sounded strange in his ears — as if he were speaking inside a cathedral, with that kind of resonance that makes words heavier, more consequential.

"In the Átnor," she answered. "The place where the map doesn't lie, because it hasn't been drawn yet."

“The Átnor of what?”

“Of everything.” She tilted her head slightly, her fingers still working at the broken wing. “Between what you were and what you’re going to be. Between what the world is and what it could be. Between the end of one story and the beginning of the next.”

“Who are you?”

The woman finished tending to the bird. The golden trace sealed the last break in the wing with a sound more felt than heard — like the click of something that had always belonged together finally finding its place.

The stone bird’s eyes went wide open. It stood still a moment, testing. Then it beat its healed wing once, twice, with a grace no creature made of granite should physically possess. It took off without a run-up, without a push — it simply rose, silently, spiraling upward until it shrank to a point against the sky of three moons and vanished into a speck of light.

The woman stood.

She was of average height, dark-skinned, her white hair tied back without ceremony in a knot. She wore a simple robe in shades of lilac and deeper purples, trimmed and embroidered — the kind of clothing that says: I am simple elegance, and I am what I appear to be. Her eyes were light brown, amber-toned, brushed through with greens like underwater forests, that particular green that only exists when light passes through both water and branches at once.

But none of that was what struck him most. It was her calm. Not the calm of someone who has never seen suffering — the calm of someone who has seen a great deal of it, and passed through to the other side, and found there not nothing, but something else. Something only those who cross all the way through ever reach.

“My name is Serena Luminara,” she said. “And you, Auron Sollis, are at the beginning of the journey you asked for before you were born.”

Auron stared at her.

“Before I was born,” he repeated.

“Before you were born.”

“People don’t ask for things before they’re born.”

Serena Luminara smiled. It was a small smile, the kind worn by someone who has had this conversation many times before and still finds something new in it, every single time.

“Some people do,” she said.

Auron wanted to laugh. It was the kind of thing you want to do when you don’t know what else to do — laugh, to create distance, to file the moment under absurd and skip the need for a serious answer. But the laugh didn’t come. The seriousness on Serena Luminara’s face was absolute, and it wasn’t a heavy seriousness, not the kind of gravity that crushes. It was more like the seriousness of a mother watching her child learn to walk while already wanting to run, who knows she’s going to let him run, who knows he’s going to fall a few times, and who knows the falling is part of the process.

“I didn’t ask for anything,” Auron shot back. “I’m a cartographer. I make maps. I don’t have some special journey, I’m not chosen, I don’t have some destiny written in the stars or in—“ he looked down at his own hands “—whatever this is on my hands.”

“The constellations?” Serena Luminara looked at his palms with the expression of someone recognizing writing in a language she knows well. “They’ve always been there. You’re only now able to see them.”

“That doesn’t make sense.”

“It makes perfect sense,” she said. “Just not the kind of sense you’re used to making. You’ve spent your whole life drawing maps of the outer world. River borders, roads between cities, distances between places. But you’ve never mapped the inside.”

“The inside of what?”

“Yours.”

Auron opened his mouth to answer and found nothing to say.

Serena Luminara touched his chest — lightly, just her fingertips, over his heart. A gentle warmth spread outward from that point of contact, the way warmth climbs up through your fingers and wrists and the rest of your body

when you wrap your hands around a hot cup of tea, in one slow, gentle current.

Auron felt knots coming undone. Not in his shoulders, not in his neck — somewhere deeper, somewhere with no anatomical name, but that everyone who's ever lived recognizes: that place where we store the things we've decided not to feel.

He cried without meaning to. The tears came before the decision to cry did, the way they do when something true happens all at once. And they were warm — not salty, warm, tasting not of sadness but of relief, the kind of relief that only comes when you set down something you've been carrying so long you only feel the weight once it's gone.

"What did you do to me?" he asked, wiping his face with the back of his hand.

"Vibrational healing," Serena Luminara answered, with the same simplicity of someone explaining something technical without making light of any of it. "Your emotional body was full of old pain you'd relabeled as personality. Pain that sticks around long enough turns into identity. I simply harmonized a few frequencies." She paused briefly. "I didn't do anything you couldn't have done yourself. Given time and willingness. But a little help never hurts."

"Emotional body," Auron repeated. "Frequencies." He rubbed his face again, still processing. "You sound like a self-help book."

"And you sound like someone afraid to believe in anything he can't put on a map," Serena Luminara answered, without any cruelty at all, just the precision of someone naming a truth she knows intimately.

Auron was about to respond — he had something forming at the edge of his lips, some defense taking shape — when a shadow crossed the corner of his vision.

It wasn't the shadow of a cloud passing over the three moons. It was someone's shadow. Auron turned his head.

"Serena Luminara. There's someone there."

She didn't startle. Didn't flinch, didn't whip her head around. She only sighed — the kind of sigh you give something expected and unwanted in equal measure.

"Yes," she said. "He always comes at the beginning."

The shadow gradually took shape, the way your eyes adjust to darkness and shapes emerge from nothing. It was an old man, with a long white beard, dressed as a pilgrim — simple, worn clothes, the kind that say I have walked many roads. He leaned on a gnarled wooden staff, crooked as the root of an ancient tree. His eyes were blue as a clear daytime sky. He walked toward Auron with the unhurried pace of someone who has all the time in the world.

He smiled.

It was a warm smile, fatherly, the kind that makes you want to trust whoever's wearing it, immediately. Auron felt the pull of it — and, at the same time, felt Serena Luminara's hand tighten slightly on his arm, a silent warning.

"My son," the old man said, in a velvet voice that seemed custom-made to be listened to. "What a joy, to find someone so alive, so awake, so ready. I am a guardian of this place. And I see in you the potential to achieve things words can barely hold."

"Is he lying?" Auron asked, low, not taking his eyes off the old man.

"Not exactly," Serena Luminara answered. "He never lies outright. He offers shortcuts."

The old man came closer. His staff touched the crystal without a sound. He held out his free hand — and in the open palm, a blue flame danced. Not an ordinary flame, not the pale blue you see at the base of a candle. A true blue flame, dense, with depth, with the kind of beauty that snags the eye and won't let go.

"Accept this gift," he said. "With it, you'll be able to see the future before it happens. Read the thoughts of the people around you. Heal sickness with the touch of a hand. You'll be sought after, admired, revered." His voice was pure honey. "And best of all: none of it requires a single step of

the journey. A journey doesn't have to be long to be complete, my son."

Auron felt the pull of it. He was honest enough with himself to admit that. The flame was beautiful. The promise was seductive in the most direct way possible — who wouldn't want to see the future? Heal the sick? Be understood without ever having to explain?

"Just a moment," Serena Luminara said.

She took Auron's hand and raised it to the level of her own eyes.

"Look down."

Auron looked. At the black crystal floor. At the shadows everything cast beneath that sky of three moons.

He had a shadow. Serena Luminara had a shadow.

The old man had none.

The silence that followed that discovery was a different kind of silence. It was the silence of understanding.

"He's not lying," Serena Luminara went on, in the same calm voice, no triumph in it, no cruelty. "But what he's offering is a toy." She lowered Auron's hand. "The flame he gives will go out at the first real test. And you'll be left emptier than before, because you'll have tasted power without the foundation real power needs to exist at all."

"And what would that foundation be?" Auron asked.

"The path," she answered simply. "The journey isn't the means to reach power. It is the power. Being the power without owning it. Every step you take, every trial you pass through, every part of yourself you find along the way — that's real power. Not the flame. The flame is the shortcut that looks like power and is only shine."

The old man listened to all of this with a patient, almost amused expression. Then he laughed — a soft laugh, almost sad, the kind that says I've heard this argument before.

"Serena Luminara. Always so suspicious," he said. "I only want to help the boy avoid needless suffering."

"You want him to stop before he starts," she answered. "Stagnation dressed up as ecstasy — that's your specialty. You hand people a single

spark, and they get so enchanted with it they forget they wanted the fire.”

The old man — whose true name, Auron would learn later, was Mára Vikalpa — stood a moment longer with the blue flame still dancing in his open palm. Then he closed his fist. The flame went out.

“You’ll remember me when you’re tired, Auron Sollis,” he said, in a voice with no anger in it, no threat, only that quiet certainty of someone who knows human nature intimately. “You’ll remember that I was here. That I offered the short road. And you’ll think: what if he was right?”

And he vanished. Not with a bang, not with smoke, none of the dramatic effects vanishings sometimes demand. He vanished with a sigh — like a candle snuffed out by the first breath of wind, so naturally you almost wonder if it was ever really lit at all.

Auron stared at the space where the old man had stood. The black crystal below reflected the three moons in miniature, three small moons pinned to the ground like coins of silver and amber.

“Who was that?”

“A tempter,” Serena Luminara said, sitting down on the crystal with the ease of someone who can sit anywhere. “Not an enemy, not in the usual sense of the word. He genuinely believes what he offers is kindness. But it’s a kindness that destroys the seeker.”

Auron sat down beside her. The crystal was soft — not like stone, not like wood, but like something caught on the border between the two that had chosen not to decide.

“How can kindness destroy someone?”

“When it takes a person away from the one thing that will actually transform them: the process.” Serena Luminara rested her arms on her knees, looking up at the moons. “Imagine you’re learning to swim. Mára Vikalpa shows up and offers you a technique that lets you float without effort. You take it. You float. You never have to actually learn to swim. And the first time you fall into deep water without that technique — you sink.”

“I get it,” Auron said. “But what about you? Are you a... friend?”

Serena Luminara turned her head to look at him. That expression again — calm, with the quiet joy of someone who knows how the story ends and likes the ending.

“I’m a part of you that you forgot,” she answered.

Auron waited for more. It didn’t come.

“That doesn’t really clear things up,” he said.

“I know.” She paused briefly. “Everyone you meet on this journey is a part of you. Fragments that became independent over time, that grew their own voices, their own ways of being in the world. We’re not your companions, not in the sense of outside people walking beside you. We’re your organs, let’s say. Necessary parts. Meeting each one is you remembering yourself.”

“Organs,” Auron repeated, trying to process that.

“I’m compassion,” Serena Luminara said simply. “What you felt when I touched your chest? The relief, the rest, the chance to be seen without needing to defend yourself? That’s the compassion that already exists inside you. I am that. I only needed to be recognized.”

Auron stayed quiet a while. The three moons kept up their slow ballet above. One of the rivers of liquid light on the ground shifted direction slightly, like a thought changing subject halfway through.

“And if I give up?” he asked, finally.

It wasn’t a threat. It was a real question — the kind people ask when they’re afraid and need to know where the emergency exit is before they walk into the building.

Serena Luminara didn’t answer right away. When she did, it was in the voice of someone stating a truth that needs no dressing up:

“You won’t.” She looked at the golden palms of Auron’s hands. “Not because you’re immune to fear. But because what’s inside you is more stubborn than your fear is. You jumped into the Rift, Auron. The hardest step is already behind you. The rest” — she smiled — “is just walking.”

The crystal floor began to ripple gently. Not the way ground ripples in an earthquake — no violence to it, none of that urgency that makes

everything shake. It rippled like the surface of still water touched by a soft wind, as if the earth were simply breathing, waking from a very long sleep with the patient laziness of ancient things.

In the distance — where the horizon met the sky of three moons along that impossible line where the world ends and the universe begins — a forest appeared. It hadn't come from nowhere: it had been there the whole time, waiting to be seen. Immense trees, trunks like cathedral columns, canopies that touched the firmament and blurred into the stars, roots that plunged into the black crystal like fingers searching for anchorage at the bottom of an ocean.

There was something about that forest Auron recognized without ever having been there before. The way you recognize a childhood smell decades later — not with memory, but with something older, more physical, more certain.

Serena Luminara stood. Held out her hand.

“Come. The second meeting is waiting for you.”

“Who’s the second?” Auron asked, taking her hand and standing up.

“Kaelen Ôm.” She started walking toward the forest, Auron beside her. “He’s going to teach you to listen to silence.”

“I already know how to listen to silence. This morning’s silence was the loudest thing I’ve ever heard.”

Serena Luminara smiled with her eyes, without looking away from the path ahead.

“Exactly,” she said.

They walked. The black crystal beneath Auron’s feet changed texture with every step — sometimes smooth as ice, sometimes grainy as fine sand, sometimes with that particular give of moss. Every step was a new texture, a new sensation, as if the ground were telling him something about itself in tactile code.

The three moons above began moving more visibly, as if they knew they had an audience. The amber one warmed. The blue-gray one cooled. The white one pulsed once, twice, three times — gently, like a contented heart.

Auron walked and thought about things he never expected to think about. He thought of his father, who had left when Auron was ten and never so much as sent a map of where he'd gone. He thought of secondary school, where a math teacher had taught geometry in a way that made the whole world seem to click into an elegant, comforting system of rules. He thought of the blank parchments on his worktable back in Veridiana, waiting for rivers his fingers hadn't been able to draw that afternoon.

He thought of the mandala.

"Serena Luminara," he said.

"Yes."

"This morning, when I tried to work, my hand drew mandalas. I've never drawn a mandala in my life."

"Your body knows things your mind is still learning to know," she answered. "Mandalas are maps of the inside. It sounds like your hands were trying to tell you something you needed to hear before you were ready to hear it."

"My mother said something similar, once. That the maps I made were about me, not about the world."

"Your mother was wise."

"She was." A pause. "Did you know her?"

Serena Luminara didn't answer right away. And when she did, it was in a way that answered without answering:

"The wisdom she had is the same wisdom that lives in you. That's the only kind of knowledge that's ever truly inherited."

Auron accepted that. Not because he understood it completely, but because there was something about that place — the crystal underfoot, the three moons above, Serena Luminara's voice — that made accepting easy. Not a numb acceptance, not the kind that belongs to someone who's given up asking questions. An active acceptance, the kind chosen by someone who decides to trust the process before understanding the whole of it.

At the edge of the forest — where the first massive trunks rose like sentinels guarding something that needed no guards, because nothing could

truly threaten it — Auron stopped.

“Serena Luminara. One last question.”

“Go ahead.”

“What’s at the end of everything?”

She stopped too. Turned to face him. And for one long second, she just looked at him with those amber-brown eyes brushed with green like underwater forests, with that calm that wasn’t the absence of feeling but feeling so complete it had turned into stillness.

Then she blinked.

“The beginning,” she said.

They walked into the forest.

The sky of three moons watched their first two steps into a journey that had no distance.

Only depth.



THE CROSSING CONTINUES.

Auron Sollis has crossed the rift. Twelve guardians remain, six tempters,
and a map he cannot yet read.

In Search of the Forgotten Spark, the complete Book I, is on Amazon in
English, Portuguese and Spanish.

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